quickly handed him over to Verma and moved on.

‘Don’t tell me you are stalking me,’ Verma said, chuckling.

‘You were not even there. That’s why I took an appointment with your boss.’

‘And he gave you all this instead of what you came for.’ Verma pointed at Anirudhya’s plateful of ‘tiffin’.

‘Like you gave me?’

‘Listen, I will talk to you soon. Till then, just chill in Madras. You studied in this city. Just hang around. What’s your problem?’

Kaarthikeyan walked up to them—he must have heard the last line Verma had said. The top cop said, ‘Anirudhya’s problem is he wants information that we don’t have.’ He then backed it up with a ‘sorry’ and left. Verma followed him. Anirudhya was now stranded in the middle of sleuths who were uncomfortable discussing work with each other in the presence of a journalist.

There was no sign of Delhi’s famous cop Amod Kanth. Anirudhya had known him ever since he was assigned the crime beat in the *Times of India* some eight years ago. A staffer helped him find Kanth. A plate with some ‘tiffin’ was on his desk, indicating he was too busy to eat. He didn’t offer Anirudhya a seat.

‘First, congratulations on your new job. *India Today* is prime.’

‘That’s true. But the *Times* is the *Times*.’

‘Of course, of course.’

‘I can see you are busy … Should I wait outside?’

‘Listen, we must catch up another time. How long would you be in Madras?’

‘I will be around. See you later?’

‘Sure thing.’

Two officers walked in. Anirudhya walked out.